# The Tuba-Zangariyye Dolmen Field

Yael Alef, Eran Mordohovich and Uri Berger

## Introduction and management context

Located on the southern edge of the Tuba-Zangariyye village in northern Israel, the dolmen field was threatened in 2015 when the Ministry of Housing and Construction proposed a residential neighborhood development on the site. This proposal was made without consulting the IAA, although the area is designated as an antiquities site under the Antiquities Law, which requires IAA approval for such developments. In response to the proposal, an archaeological survey mapped the remains within the planning area. At this stage, significance assessment was not conducted, resulting in only a few dolmens being identified for preservation in isolated locations. The IAA conditionally approved the development plan, contingent on a salvage excavation being carried out. This ultimately condemned most of the dolmens and the megalithic landscape to destruction. As the planning progressed, it only partially adhered to the IAA conditions, and infrastructure was planned close to the remaining dolmens, which would have practically eliminated them had the plan been implemented.

This reflects the common approach in Israel until recently, where the dolmens did not receive appropriate attention from most archaeologists and have been largely overlooked by development and major archaeological enterprises. With the growing development pressures in the last decades, the practice of salvage excavation as a management policy has resulted in the destruction of numerous dolmens in the Golan Heights and the Korazim Plateau. Despite their historical and cultural significance, dozens of dolmens have been damaged by basalt mining in the Golan Heights and the Korazim Plateau for the construction of ports and the development of towns and villages. Even in instances where the dolmens themselves were preserved, their setting in the landscape and context were often destroyed.

Fortunately, that was not the end of the story for the Tuba-Zangariyye dolmen field. In 2019, the development plan was expanded, and consequently, an additional archaeological survey was conducted in the expanded area (see Fig. 1). During this time, the IAA became more aware of contemporary practices in archaeological resource management. This included a recognition of the policy presumption for the preservation of archaeological heritage in situ, which is enshrined as one of the principles in the Valletta Convention, as well as the need for an integrated approach to the conservation of archaeological heritage. This awareness was further complemented by recognizing the importance of a holistic approach to the cultural landscape and incorporating the concept of value-based management. The renewed survey thus presented an opportunity to clarify the significance of the dolmens and the importance of the megalithic cultural landscape. It also allowed for the establishment of new guidelines to integrate the remains into the development plan.

**The legal system**

The Israeli Antiquities Law of 1978[1] designates the IAA to oversee and manage the country's archaeological sites and artifacts. According to the law, "antiquity" is defined as "Any object, whether detached or fixed, which was made by man before the year 1700 of the general era and

[1] Antiquities Law https://www.antiquities.org.il/article_eng.aspx?sec_id=42&subj_id=228

includes anything subsequently added thereto which forms an integral part thereof". An "antiquity site" indicates an area that contains antiquities.

Under the law, the IAA is responsible for conducting archaeological surveys and registering antiquity sites. It is also tasked with regulating any construction or development that may impact these sites. Any proposed development within the area of a registered antiquity site must receive approval from the IAA. When a development plan is submitted for approval, the IAA will either conduct a survey or trial trenches and/or digs to identify potential remains. Based on the results, it will decide whether to approve the plan with no further conditions, reject the plan, or require salvage excavations before permitting development activities. The IAA may also mandate mitigation measures to protect archaeological sites during construction.

More than 30,000 antiquity sites are currently registered under the Antiquities Law. However, while the law effectively regulates the discovery, excavation, and ownership of antiquities, it lacks robust tools for designating sites for preservation. As a matter of fact, archaeological sites that merit preservation must be statutorily protected under the 1965 Planning and Building Law.

**The evaluation system**

In Israel, the authorities do not implement a formal evaluation system for designating archaeological sites for preservation. The following text adopts a significance assessment information model (Alef, 2021) and guidelines for cultural significance assessment developed by the author. These guidelines are intended for the training Archaeological Resource Management (ARM) practitioners in academia and the Israel Antiquities Authority (IAA). They are based on a Context-Based Significance Assessment (CBSA) approach, which aims to place the site within broader historical processes, enabling the perception of broad patterns and how individual resources fit within these patterns. This approach also helps to explain spatial and cultural interconnections (Briuer & Mathers, 1997; Carman, 2015; Hardesty & Little, 2009; Mathers, Darvill, & Little, 2005).

CBSA evaluates a site within its historical themes and geographical contexts. Common criteria for evaluating archaeological sites include the period; quality of the remains (in terms of integrity and preservation); rarity; representativeness; vulnerability; documentation; aesthetics; and research potential. However, it should be noted that in addition to the changing nature of significance in relation to cultural agendas, academic and professional literature does not specify precisely what needs to be done to assess these qualities. Generally, these qualities refer to academic and scientific value, changes over time, local and community values, and wider public benefits (Carman, 2015).

The CBSA model suggests complementing the site description with the following steps:

1. Identify the cultural elements and context components, including (a) typological, structural, and geographical context; (b) historical information referring to figures, events, and processes related to the site or its context; (c) cultural themes related to stories and figures, artistic themes depicted in artifacts, traditions, and practices.
2. Articulate the cultural significance, explaining why these elements are significant.
3. Contextualize the cultural significance in relation to the themes, demonstrating how the broader context amplifies this significance.
4. Compare the site to other similar sites to highlight its uniqueness or representativeness, including the integrity of the remains. Consider factors such as rarity, workmanship, and artistic quality.

5. Write a concise summary integrating all the previous points into a cohesive narrative.
- Where relevant in the description or cultural significance assessment, refer to the quality of information, such as available sources, the richness of data, as well as uncertainties or different explanations for phenomena.

## Description of the site

The Tuba-Zangariyye dolmen field is situated on a hill in the basalt Korazim Plateau, which stretches in the Jordan Rift Valley, between the Sea of Galilee in the south and the Hula Valley in the north (see fig. 2). This field is part of the larger Korazim dolmen field which is the western extension of the vast megalithic field of southern Syria and upper Jordan.

Throughout history, the plateau was home to semi-nomadic cattle herders and pastoralists who lived in temporary dwellings, leaving behind stone animal pens as a common feature in the area. However, the most significant archaeological elements on the plateau are approximately 500 dolmens and a few hundred more tumuli that dominate the landscape. These are dated to the Intermediate Bronze Age, around the end of the 3rd to the early 2nd millennia B.C.E. (4,500-4,000 years ago) and represent the latest in a series of megalithic monuments of the Jordan Valley and the Golan Heights (Stepansky, 2005).

In 1877, Herbert Kitchener, who later commanded the British Empire Army during World War I, reported that while surveying the area of the Zangariyye tribes for the Palestine Exploration Fund, they discovered the first perfect dolmen he had seen in the country, which was called Hajr ed Dum, or "the stone of blood" (Kitchener, 1877) (see Fig. 3). This dolmen was part of a large field of dolmens on the Korazim Plateau, identified by Karge in 1917. The field was later included in a report on Prehistoric Galilee by Francis Turville-Petre in the 1920s, who also excavated 24 dolmens in the area. Following Moshe Stekelis in the 1960s and Claire Epstein in the 1970s, research continued into the 1990s with the IAA survey of Israel by Yosef Stepansky, who documented 578 dolmens on the Korazim Plateau. A few dolmens were also excavated as part of local salvage excavations (Berger & Sharon, 2018).

The dolmens located in Tuba-Zangariyye form part of the ancient landscape that was already familiar during Biblical times. It is possible that they are related to references in the Bible about giants who inhabited the eastern Transjordan. As stated in Deuteronomy 2:21, "That also was accounted a land of giants: giants dwelt therein in old time…". Among them was Og, the giant king of the Bashan. Additionally, there are references to dolmen in the Korazim area, which may be the "tombs" described in the miracle of the pigs where Jesus casts out demons from the body of a madman. Mark 5:2-3 states, "When Jesus got out of the boat, a man with an impure spirit came from the tombs to meet him. This man lived in the tombs."… (Stepansky, 2005)

The Tuba-Zangariyye field includes more than 65 dolmens and more than 20 tumuli over an area of about 0.5 square kilometers. It consists of several types of dolmens, most of which are small with 1.5 - 3m long closed chambers and 1-2 covering stones. The size of the covering stones varies, with an average of 0.5 X 1.5X 3 m, but some single stones may weigh as much as 15 tons. Some of the dolmens stand out conspicuously and can be seen from afar due to a large capstone that covers the dolmen chamber or its tumulus (see fig. 4).

Another type of dolmen is covered by tumuli, consisting of various-sized fieldstones. In many instances, one can discern within them or around their circumference remains of walls, adding

an even more commanding and monumental appearance. The average sizes of tumuli are 5 to 10m in diameter and 1-2m in height, but some reach sizes of 15-20m x 3m. Those dolmens without a tumulus are usually enclosed by a stone circle or by scattered stones placed evenly or without order around the structure (Stepansky, 2005).

The hundreds of dolmens and tumuli, form the characteristic cultural landscape of the Korazim Plateau. The Korazim dolmen field is the largest of its kind west of the Jordan River and one of the densest megalithic burial fields in the world. Within it, is the well-preserved Tuba dolmen field.

Each dolmen is a product of an engineering construction effort that attests to a developed social organization, a sophisticated culture, and high technological knowledge and abilities.

The first basalt dolmen discovered in Israel was found in this field, documented as early as 1877. This discovery sparked ongoing research into this culture. These burial structures they left behind provide us with the most information about this culture. This relics are all that remain of a civilization that sanctified its dead with monumental structures unknown in the area at any other historical period.

Since the discovery of dolmens in the Levant, there has been debate about their dating, and culture of one of the most interesting phenomena in the archaeology of the Levant.

The remains stand almost as they, creating a unique landscape known since biblical times, until recent times when the Bedouin Zangariyye tribes grazed their flocks in the area. Sadly, over the past 150 years, dozens of dolmens in the area have been damaged and destroyed due to development activities. Today, after extensive destruction, this dolmen field is a rare and almost the last remnant of this cultural landscape.

## Results/outcomes

The findings of the survey and evaluation were presented to the planners of the Ministry of Housing during a field visit. The result was a compromise in which the IAA was asked to redefine the areas for preservation and development in a manner that preserves the greatest number of dolmens and enables the development of the rest of the area. Based on the significance assessment, conservation principles have been at the forefront of planning efforts for the Tuba-Zangariyye dolmen field. These principles include preserving the dolmens as part of the megalithic landscape in an open and connected area; minimizing the impact of infrastructure and roads on the concentration of dolmens; preserving prominent individual dolmens; and incorporating dolmens into the planning of public buildings and tourism land use. Efforts have also been made to ensure that development works do not damage or cover the remaining dolmens. These principles were integrated in recent planning versions, and it remains to be seen how they will be implemented in the final plan and in subsequent detailed planning stages.

The case study illustrates a gradual shift in the IAA's practice from relying primarily on the Antiquities Law, which has proven insufficient for the effective protection and preservation of archaeological heritage, to integrating the site into the development plan. Other current ARM principles that emphasize community participation are another challenge for the future.

*The authors would like to thank Jon Seligman for his thoughtful comments on the case study.

## References


Alef, Y. (2021). *Information Needs of Archaeological Sites Evaluation for Cultural Heritage Management Inventory: The Case of the Ancient Synagogues in Northern Israel.* (Bar Ilan University). Retrieved from https://bit.ly/45Msp24

Berger, U., & Sharon, G. (2018). Dolmens of the Hula Basin. *Mitekufat Haeven: Journal of the Israel Prehistoric Society*, *48*, 147–166. Retrieved from https://www.jstor.org/stable/pdf/26579627.pdf

Briuer, F. L., & Mathers, C. (1997). *Trends, and Patterns in Cultural Resource significance: an historical perspective and annotated bibliography*. Retrieved from https://erdc-library.erdc.dren.mil/jspui/bitstream/11681/9986/1/TR EL-97-5.pdf

Carman, J. (2015). Evaluation. In *Archaeological Resource Management: An International Perspective* (pp. 105–130). chapter, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Hardesty, D. L., & Little, B. J. (2009). *Assessing Site Significance : A Guide for Archaeologists and Historians* (2nd ed).

Kitchener, H. H. (1877). Lieutenant Kitchener's Reports II: Camp at Tiberias, 30th March, 1877. In *Palestine Exploration Fund Quarterly Statement*: *Vol. 9/3*. Retrieved from https://biblicalstudies.org.uk/pdf/pefqs/1877-03_116.pdf

Mathers, C., Darvill, T., & Little, B. J. (2005). Introduction: Archaeological value in a world context. In C. Mathers, T. Darvill, & B. Little (Eds.), *Heritage of Value, Archaeology of Renown: Reshaping Archaeological Assessment and Significance* (pp. 1–20). University Press of Florida.

Stepansky, Y. (2005). The Megalithic Culture of the Corazim Plateau, Eastern Galilee, Israel: New Evidence for a Chronological and Social Framework. *Mediterranean Archaeology and Archaeometry*, *5*(1), 39–50.

Figures Captions

Fig. 1 IAA archaeologist surveying a dolmen in the Tuba-Zangariyye field, with the village in the background (Photo taken by E. Mordohovich, 2019).

Fig. 2 Survey map of the Tuba-Zangariyye dolmen field on the Korazim Plateau showing its dense concentration of dolmens.

Fig. 3 An historic photo of dolmen in the Tuba-Zangariyye vicinity, possibly the Hajar ed Dumm dolmen mentioned by Kitchner in 1877. (B. Rothenberg, 1955, Meitar Collection, The Pritzker Family National Photography Collection, The National Library of Israel)

Fig. 4 Aerial view of a dolmen from the Tuba-Zangariyye field and its surrounding (Photo taken by A. Kleiner, 2019)